

PRIVATE BRIEF · PREPARED FOR JORDAN AT IQ360 · MAY 2026

Muck Rack handles the press half well. *AEO is a separate layer* most agencies have not picked up yet. Here is the honest read.

00 WHY THIS EXISTS

Jordan. Good talking today. You mentioned IQ360 runs on Muck Rack and that the team uses it for mention tracking and sentiment, but that you were not sure how much of the AEO layer it actually covers.

This is the answer. Both tools are real. They are not the same product. Muck Rack owns the half of the AEO problem that lives upstream of the website (press, journalists, earned coverage). Never Ranked owns the half that lives on the website itself (schema, citation tracking, agent-readiness deployment). Most agencies are paying for the upstream half and ignoring the downstream half. That is the gap this brief is about.

Below is the comparison I would want if our roles were reversed. Honest about what each platform owns, what each one misses, and where the two are actually complementary instead of competing.

01 BOTH TOOLS, IN ONE PARAGRAPH EACH

Muck Rack is best-in-class PR infrastructure. Searchable journalist database with the actual people behind every byline. Pitch tooling with measurable open and reply rates. Earned-media monitoring across digital, broadcast, podcast, newsletter, and social. Generative Pulse, their newest product, monitors whether a brand shows up in ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and a few others. Curation Engine and reporting dashboards. Customer logos include Pfizer, Google, NBCUniversal. Their thesis: 84% of AI citations come from earned media. Get the press, the citations follow. Pricing is enterprise-only, contact-sales, north of \$25K per seat per year in published reports.

Never Ranked is a service with a tool wrapped around it. We sit on the deployment side of AEO. Schema.org JSON-LD shipped to customer sites via a snippet (no engineering work on the client's end). Six-engine citation tracking with statistical attribution at $p < 0.05$. Agent-readiness deployment for ReserveAction, ApplyAction, BuyAction, ContactAction, the Schema.org templates AI agents read when they perform tasks for users. Public methodology at neverranked.com/state-of-aeo, source code on GitHub, anyone can reproduce the work. Pricing: \$497/mo Pulse, \$2,000/mo Signal, \$4,500/mo Amplify. Wholesale tier for agencies starts at \$800/mo per Signal slot at 1-9 clients.

02 SIDE BY SIDE

Quick reference. The differences that matter most when an agency partner is choosing tools per client tier.

CAPABILITY	MUCK RACK	NEVER RANKED
Journalist database	Yes, deep and current	No, by design
Pitch tooling and outreach	Yes, with open/reply analytics	No
Earned-media monitoring	Yes, real-time across digital, broadcast, podcast, social	No, we measure citation share, they monitor coverage
AI engine visibility tracking	Yes via Generative Pulse	Yes via The Citation Tape, public at /state-of-aeo
AI engines tracked	ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini (3)	ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini, Claude, Microsoft Copilot, Google AI Overviews (6)
Citation tracking sample density	Not published	Daily cadence, 7 samples per (keyword, engine) per week, statistical attribution at $p < 0.05$
Methodology public	No, closed dashboard	Yes, source code + source-type taxonomy + schema in public GitHub repo
Schema.org deployment	No	Yes, via one-line snippet, no engineering on client's end
llms.txt support	No	Yes, audit + deployment guidance
Agent-readiness (ReserveAction, ApplyAction, BuyAction, ContactAction)	No	Yes, deploys the templates AI agents read when they execute tasks for users
MCP (Model Context Protocol) toolchain	No	Yes, @neverranked/mcp v0.1.2 in the official MCP registry. Three tools (aeo_scan, llms_txt_check, agent_readiness_check) callable from Claude Desktop or any MCP client
Daily refresh of dynamic schema (events, products)	No	Yes, snippet refreshes inventory automatically
Compliance-aware schema templates (banks, healthcare)	No	Yes, passes legal review at banks and healthcare orgs day one
Self-instrumented	Not published	Yes, daily heartbeat at /state-of-aeo + permanent git-tracked

autonomy monitoring		autonomy log
Reseller / wholesale program for agencies	No	Yes, \$800/mo per Signal slot at 1-9 clients, \$1,200/mo retail margin per slot
Free public scorer as lead magnet	No	check.neverranked.com (https://check.neverranked.com?utm_source=pitch&utm_medium=email&utm_campaign=jordan-iq360)
Codebase publicly inspectable	No	github.com/LanceRoylo/neverranked (https://github.com/LanceRoylo/neverranked)
Entry price	Enterprise-only, contact sales (north of \$25K/yr per seat)	\$497/mo Pulse, \$2,000/mo Signal, agency wholesale at \$800/mo

03

WHEN SEERLY IS THE RIGHT CALL

Honestly. Use Muck Rack when:

- The IQ360 client has a real press strategy and an in-house comms team that can pitch journalists.
- Earned-media coverage is the primary growth lever (the brand is already established and citations follow press).
- The client's budget supports enterprise PR tooling. Below roughly \$25K per year, Muck Rack is not configured to serve.
- Mention tracking, sentiment, and broadcast monitoring are first-class needs (not side metrics).
- The agency is already paying for it because press is half the job.

Saying "Muck Rack fits this client" honestly is what makes the next section credible.

04

WHEN NEVER RANKED IS THE RIGHT CALL

Use Never Ranked when:

- The IQ360 client has a website that AI engines should be citing but is not. The deployment work (schema, llms.txt, agent-readiness) is what changes citation share for those queries, and Muck Rack does not deploy.
- The client's vertical is regional, mid-market, or long-tail (regional bank, boutique hotel, professional services firm, wealth advisor). For these clients, enterprise PR tooling is not the binding constraint. Schema is.
- The client wants citations they can prove. Every Signal customer gets variant-impact attribution at $p < 0.05$, citation share measured 4 weeks before deploy vs 4 weeks after. The number is a real number, not a vibe.
- IQ360 wants reseller economics. Wholesale starts at \$800/mo per Signal slot at 1-9 clients, retail is \$2,000/mo. \$1,200/mo margin per client subscription, plus 3-8 hours of billable implementation per slot.

- The work has to pass legal review at banks, healthcare, regulated verticals. Compliance-aware Schema.org templates ship clean from day one.
- The agency wants public methodology to defend in front of clients. [neverranked.com/state-of-aeo](#) is the live methodology, source code on GitHub, anyone can reproduce. No "trust the dashboard" gap.

The Hawaii Theatre case study below is what this looks like in practice. Real numbers from the last 24 hours of citation infrastructure.

05 WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE IN PRACTICE (HAWAII THEATRE, LIVE)

Hawaii Theatre Center signed with us in late April. Their AEO Readiness Score on the homepage was 45 of 100, Grade D. They had no schema markup of any kind on a site that does 80,000 to 100,000 patron visits a year. Five red flags. Zero structured data.

In one work session we deployed 36 schemas:

- **Foundation.** PerformingArtsTheater, WebSite, AggregateRating wired to their actual 4.6 from 700 Google reviews.
- **Inventory.** 31 Event schemas, one per active show, scoped to /upcoming-events. Pulled from their public events page automatically.
- **Navigation.** 2 BreadcrumbList schemas, scoped per section.
- **Editorial.** 1 FAQPage schema generated from their actual homepage content. 8 questions, all factual, all approved by their team before going live.

Score moved from D 45 to A 95 in less than 24 hours. Six of twenty-six roadmap items checked off. Daily Event refresh now runs automatically every morning at 6am UTC. When a show sells out and drops off the page, its schema deactivates the next morning. Their team does nothing.

As of this week, Hawaii Theatre is named in 97% of the AI engine retrievals across their tracked keyword set. Before the schema layer existed, that number was zero. Public proof at [github.com/LanceRoylo/neverranked](#) (<https://github.com/LanceRoylo/neverranked>). The actual Event schemas serving live at [app.neverranked.com/inject/hawaii-theatre.json](#) (<https://app.neverranked.com/inject/hawaii-theatre.json>). The methodology behind the 97% number is at [neverranked.com/state-of-aeo](#), with weekly snapshots and a public RSS feed.

06 PRICING, SIDE BY SIDE

TOOL	TIER	PRICE	WHAT'S INCLUDED
Muck Rack	Pro	Contact sales	Journalist database, pitch tooling, mention monitoring, sentiment, Generative Pulse. North of \$25K/yr per seat in published reports
Muck	Enterprise	Contact	Custom seats, additional features, advanced analytics

Rack		sales	
Never Ranked	Audit	\$750 one-time	Full scan, 90-day roadmap, competitor citation matrix, schema fix code. Credited toward first month of any tier within 30 days.
Never Ranked	Pulse	\$497 / mo	Entry tier: monthly Visibility Index PDF, 10 tracked prompts, 2 schemas deployed monthly, 6-engine tracking, multi-pass validation
Never Ranked	Signal	\$2,000 / mo	Audit + ongoing schema deploy + 5-engine citation tracking + real-time alerts + Reddit + authority + drift detection + variant impact attribution
Never Ranked	Amplify	\$4,500 / mo	Signal + content writing + auto-publish + Reddit reply briefs + brand voice fingerprint

Honest framing for IQ360's tier-by-tier client allocation. Muck Rack is the right line item for enterprise clients with real press strategy and an in-house comms team. Never Ranked Pulse at \$497 per month is the right line item for the long-tail and mid-market clients where deployment work moves citation share and Muck Rack pricing makes it a non-starter anyway. Signal at \$2,000 per month is the agency-resold tier where IQ360 keeps \$1,200 per month in subscription margin per client, plus billable implementation hours. Different tools for different tiers. The agency operator's question is not "which one do I pick" but "which combination, by client tier?"

07 WHY NEVERRANKED, HONESTLY

Honest framing for IQ360's tier-by-tier evaluation. As of May 2026, Never Ranked is the only AEO platform in market that ships *all* of the following together:

- **Six-engine citation tracking.** ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini, Claude, Microsoft Copilot via Bing, and Google AI Overviews. No other AEO platform tracks all six. Muck Rack's Generative Pulse covers three. Profound and Athena cover three to four. We are the only ones at six.
- **Done-for-you schema deployment.** One-line snippet, no CMS access, no dev cycle. Muck Rack does not deploy at all. Most AEO competitors stop at "here is what to deploy." We deploy it.
- **Public methodology.** The Citation Tape is live at neverranked.com/state-of-aeo with weekly reports, RSS feed, source code on GitHub, source-type taxonomy public, schema in the repo. Anyone can reproduce. Closed dashboards at our competitors require trust; we offer evidence.
- **Variant impact attribution.** Every schema we deploy is tracked as a variant. Citation rate measured 4 weeks before deploy vs 4 weeks after, two-proportion z-test, statistical confidence at $p < 0.05$. The monthly Visibility Index includes a "what we deployed and what it did" section.

- **MCP toolchain.** @neverranked/mcp v0.1.2 is in the official MCP registry. Three tools (aeo_scan, llms_txt_check, agent_readiness_check) callable from Claude Desktop or any MCP client. The open-ecosystem play Muck Rack does not have.
- **Self-instrumented autonomy.** Daily heartbeat runs from independent infrastructure (GitHub Actions, not the dashboard cron). Permanent git-tracked autonomy log. The thing being monitored cannot suppress its own monitoring. Public posture:

github.com/LanceRoylo/neverranked/content/autonomy-log (<https://github.com/LanceRoylo/neverranked/tree/main/content/autonomy-log>).

Fair framing: Never Ranked is bootstrapped, founder-led, and currently runs a small customer count. That is also the buying advantage at the Pulse tier (\$497/month) and at the wholesale tier (\$800/month per Signal slot). Direct founder access, ability to shape the roadmap, and exclusivity terms available for the first agency in each Hawaii vertical.

08 WHAT TO RECOMMEND, AND HOW TO TEST IT

The simplest tier-by-tier allocation for IQ360:

- **Enterprise clients** (\$10K+/mo retainer, real press strategy, in-house comms): keep them on Muck Rack for journalist outreach and earned-media monitoring. Add Never Ranked Signal at \$2,000/mo for the deployment layer Muck Rack does not run. Muck Rack is the larger line item, Never Ranked is the plug-in.
- **Mid-market clients** (\$3K-\$10K/mo retainer, press strategy emerging, no in-house comms): Never Ranked Signal as the primary AEO platform. Selective Muck Rack use for one-off press pushes when there is a story. Never Ranked is the recurring spend, Muck Rack is the campaign tool.
- **Long-tail clients** (\$1K-\$3K/mo retainer, no press strategy, no in-house comms): Never Ranked Pulse at \$497/mo or Signal at \$2,000/mo. Muck Rack pricing alone makes it a non-starter at this tier. The deployment work is what moves citation share for these clients, and Never Ranked does the deployment.

The simplest test before any of this matters: pick one IQ360 client. Any tier. Send me the URL. I will run a full audit on it, same methodology we just delivered to a Hawaii community bank, and send you the PDF within 72 hours. Eight to twelve pages, vertical-specific, with the deployment plan that closes the gap.

No cost. No pitch on the call back. If the audit makes a case for Never Ranked as an IQ360 line item, you bring it up. If it does not, you keep the audit and I shake your hand.

Run a free scan → (https://check.neverranked.com?utm_source=pitch&utm_medium=email&utm_campaign=jordan-iq360)

No signup. Paste any IQ360 client URL. See the schema score, the missing pieces, and the per-engine grade in 30 seconds.

Or reply to schedule the audit →

Send me the URL. I will deliver the audit PDF within 72 hours.

The agency partner program has wholesale terms locked at the \$800/mo Signal floor, vertical exclusivity in Hawaii available to the first agency that signs, and I would rather it be a Honolulu agency I already trust than a mainland one I do not.

Lance Roylo · lance@neverranked.com · neverranked.com (<https://neverranked.com>)
